wired into the media—if beat reporters of newspapers and channels had to vote for their favourite politician, Jaitley might win comfortably.

There was also Rajnath Singh, a former UP chief minister who liked to see himself as a consensus builder with friends across parties. As a proud Thakur from the Hindi heartland, he'd often been accused of strong caste loyalties and was not above low cunning, and sidelining his rivals. His personal astrologer had apparently told him 2014 would be a big year for him.

But for all their strengths, the triumvirate of Delhi-based leadership aspirants did not have a genuine mass base nor had they delivered election victories. The BJP was looking for a vote catcher and Modi in the spring of 2013 had the look and feel of one.

Three weeks after the national council meet, Modi was inducted into the BJP's parliamentary board, its highest decision-making body, the only BJP chief minister to get that honour. A few days later, I interviewed Rajnath Singh and asked him the obvious question—would Modi now be made the BJP's prime ministerial candidate? Singh, a smooth talker who had refined political diplomacy to a fine art, was evasive. 'Our party has many capable leaders. We are a democratic party and the parliamentary board will decide the leadership issue at the appropriate time.' I persisted, 'But isn't Modi the most popular BJP leader today?' Singh's answer was revealing. 'Yes, Narendrabhai is the most popular chief minister. *Logon mein unka jadoo toh hai* [There is Modi magic among people].' I had got my answer. Modi was no longer first among equals. He was THE BJP leader of the future. Only one man disagreed—the person who had once been seen, ironically, as a mentor of the Gujarat chief minister. As Modi's graph rose inexorably, a combative senior citizen readied for revolt.

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Goa will always have a special place in the life and times of Modi. It was here that his political career was saved in the aftermath of the 2002 riots. And it was here in June 2013 that he was made the chairman of the BJP's